

► SEWING MACHINE

You can use any modern sewing machine for quilting as long as you can adjust the stitch length and the machine has a zigzag function. Other useful features to look for are feed dogs – the toothed bars in the needle plate that feed the fabric through – that can be dropped, and a large throat area – the area between the needle plate

and the machine's horizontal arm. This is useful when working on a bulky item. Needle sizes are in metric (e.g. 70) and universal/American (e.g. 10). For quilting you will need a range of needles in sizes from 70/10 to 90/14, depending on your project.



FEET

All sewing machines come with a standard presser foot as well as a selection of specialized feet for different purposes. You should have a 6mm ($\frac{1}{4}$ in) seam foot for piecing patchwork. Also useful for quilting are:



Walking foot

This strange-looking foot “walks” across the fabric, so that the upper layer of fabric is not pushed forward. When used for quilting, it also guides the layers of fabric and wadding through the feed dogs at an even speed. Also commonly known as an even feed foot.



Zip foot

This foot fits to either the right- or left-hand side of the needle and is normally used for stitching close to the teeth of a zip. If you are finishing the edges of a quilt with piping, it enables you to stitch close to the piping cord.



Darning foot

Also known as a free-motion quilting foot, this foot “floats” on a spring mechanism for free-motion quilting of fancy patterns. The clear acrylic foot gives you a good view of your stitching area.